A Uniform is Uniform

The Army was the first to introduce the camouflage pattern of uniform, more simply known as Combat Dress, in the 1980s, replacing the olive-green uniform with a disruptive pattern battle dress that provided an inbuilt element of camouflage. Prior to that, the field dress was the same olive-green uniform after removing all accoutrements and replacing brass badges of rank with cloth epaulettes. Over the years, the other Services, Para-Military Forces and CAPF followed suit. The result was that there was a plethora of similar-looking camouflage pattern combat dresses floating around, making it difficult to identify who is who. Moreover, although the Ordnance Factory Board (OFB) was mandated to produce these uniforms from cloth sourced through the industry, other private players could also do the same. This pattern became so popular that it was used for everything from car seat covers to *shamianas* (marquees). The sanctity of the combat dress had been lost and we had experienced its deleterious effect when called in for Aid to Civil Authority, to contain the Jat agitation of 2016, with some people even saying that they had seen Army personnel 'running away'.

With that in mind, it was decided to evolve a unique pattern to that in use since 2008, that would not only be more modern but unique to the Indian Army. The responsibility for this devolved on the AG and MGO, and the National Institute of Fashion Technology (NIFT) was roped in for this purpose. Several factors went into the new design. The NIFT created separate teams to look into aspects related to the design of the pattern, modern light-weight fabric and prototyping. The NIFT team was very patient with us, and I must go on record to appreciate their efforts. Ultimately, more than seventeen

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